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RLD: SHIFTING SANDS PG 16

QATAR: A DIPLOMATIC COUP PG 24



TEARS FOR FEARS
Farmers brave teargas shells at the Shambhu border, Feb. 13

ANI

FARMERS' PROTESTS

WHY FARMERS ARE ANGRY AGAIN

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

The heavy-duty tractors at Shambhu in Patiala near the Punjab-Haryana border had turned up the volume. The songs blaring out predicted dire consequences for Delhi (the Centre) and eulogised the bravado of the Jat Sikh community, as the cavalcade rumbled on to lay siege to the national capital on February 13. The protesting farmers claimed they were carrying rations and diesel to last for months. Right about then, the skies started raining teargas shells, fired from drones by the security personnel manning the barricades.

All this was reminiscent of the 13-month siege the national capital had witnessed (Sept. 2020-Nov. 2021), just that the farmers hadn't reached the gates of Delhi yet. The siege had forced Prime Minister Narendra Modi's government to back down then and withdraw the big-ticket farm sector reforms. With the general election just months away, the threat of a long-drawn protest has again got the ruling BJP worried. The farmer unions have had two rounds of talks so